

"WE HAD THE COURAGE TO CHANGE POLICY"

While returning from the G-8 summit in Germany in June, on board his special aircraft, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh agreed to discuss with Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA why he entered into a deal with the US on civilian nuclear power. The understanding was that excerpts of it could be published once the 123 Agreement was reached.

ON WHY THE NUCLEAR DEAL WITH THE US

The nuclear deal was a logical fall-out of the Next Steps in the Strategic Partnership that the NDA government had begun with the US. It was an outcome of that process. Nuclear power is critical to our energy security if we want to be a world power. While we

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had successfully made nuclear weapons, on the power front I felt there were too many shifting targets. We had set a target of 10,000 MW of nuclear power almost 35 years ago and now we have only around 3,700 MW. The deal would help us meet our targets for nuclear power.

ON ITS IMPACT ON WEAPONS PROGRAMME

President Bush told me (in July, 2005), don't expect me to help you to build bombs. I told him I didn't expect the US to do that because with our previous achievements we didn't need anyone's help. I made it clear during the negotiations that we can't agree to a bilateral NPT or CTBT. We have a unilateral moratorium on nuclear testing and we will exercise restraint.

ON BUSH AND INDIA'S TIES WITH THE US

President Bush is a very easy per-

son to deal with. He puts you at ease and listens carefully. He is very nice to me and of all the US presidents, he is the friendliest towards India. The US had become the sole superpower almost 15 years ago. But all these years no Indian government had the courage to change our policy towards the US. When we did a foreign policy review, we felt, in a globalised world, Indo-US relations were the key and we needed to give them the highest importance. We have stayed that course.

ON CHARGES OF TILTING TOWARDS THE US

I believe in being friends to all countries and we had to open new pathways to do that. We need to change the cycle. The guiding principle is to resolve disputes without creating fear and uncertainty. On Pakistan and China, we are on track. In Indo-US relations, the nuclear issue was an irritant and the deal works towards removing that. As regards our international status, in major forums now China and India are mentioned in the same breath. That is something deeply satisfying. But there is no scope for complacency. We can't take our place in the world for granted. We need to work harder, harder, harder.

ON US PRESSURE ON INDIA OVER IRAN

It's not in our interests for Iran to become a nuclear weapons power. But as an NPT member, it has a right to have nuclear energy. I told President Bush, I can't be a cheer leader or be part of a warmongering group. The nuclear dispute with Iran should be resolved through peaceful processes.

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through the IAEA and no threats.

ON HIS COMMITMENTS TO PARLIAMENT

We wanted to be transparent because of the deep suspicions about the US among our political, intellectual and scientific class. In Parliament, we drew redlines on the deal that we wouldn't cross. I even told President Bush that just as he has a Congress, I have one too. My commitments to Parliament acted as a disciplining force without which we would have been vulnerable while negotiating with the US later.

ON THE ATTITUDE OF OPPOSITION PARTIES

It requires a big leap in approach and the attitude of BJP is disappointing. They didn't even believe I would last as the prime minister and some leaders even did *havans* that I should die on a certain day. But I have faith in a higher force. I believe it was my destiny to be the prime minister. I have the courage of conviction.

ON CRITICISM FROM NUCLEAR SCIENTISTS

I have a great respect for them. Although they don't have a veto on the deal, I felt we needed them to be on board. They had faced the bad side of the US—the isolation and the suspicion—and I had to take them along.

ON HOW HE VIEWS NUCLEAR WEAPONS

I feel dreadful about a world full of nuclear weapons. Now there are even dangers of a dirty bomb and non state actors using it. The world could end up with a catastrophe and universal nuclear disarmament is a must.